

API Community of practice.

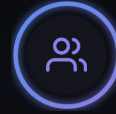
From Fragmented Capability to Connected Ecosystem



Client Banking Client (Tier-1 African Bank)



Engagement API Community of Practice



Team: 7 Designers **My Role** UX Researcher

Shared for portfolio purposes under NDA. Client identity, verbatim findings, and internal artifacts have been anonymized or generalized to protect confidentiality. The Community of Practice covered here has not yet been built or shipped.

A discovery engagement for the human layer of the ecosystem

The API Marketplace already exists as a live platform. What hadn't been resolved was the human side: whether teams trusted, found, and reused what was on it. This case study covers the discovery phase for the proposed API Community of Practice.



The Ask

Establish qualitative evidence of how the live API Marketplace was being experienced, to inform the design of the Community of Practice.



The Gap

Leadership suspected collaboration, discoverability, and reuse were breaking down on the platform but had no structured evidence of where or why.



Confidentiality

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Worked on the research end-to-end, from protocol to insight



01 - Protocol Design

Designed the full interview protocol: research objectives, opening/consent framing, a five-section question flow, scenario-based prompts, and role-specific tracks for executives.



02 - Stakeholder Interviews

Facilitated 16 interviews across solution architects, SMEs, business analysts, developers, UX designers, Heads of APIs, and executives.



03 - Mapping & Synthesis

Clustered raw interview data into affinity groups, surfaced recurring patterns, and distilled them into thematic insights and a maturity read for leadership.

WHAT I OWNED

The interview protocol, 9/16 of the interviews, and facilitating both the affinity mapping exercise and the ideation session.

WHAT I SHARED WITH THE TEAM OF 7

Reviewing the patterns before they became findings, and the machine-to-organism reframe we recommended to leadership.

Four objectives shaped every question I wrote

1

Understand how the API ecosystem is experienced across product, platform, architecture, engineering, delivery, and business teams.

2

Identify opportunities and barriers related to collaboration, discoverability, reuse, and knowledge-sharing.

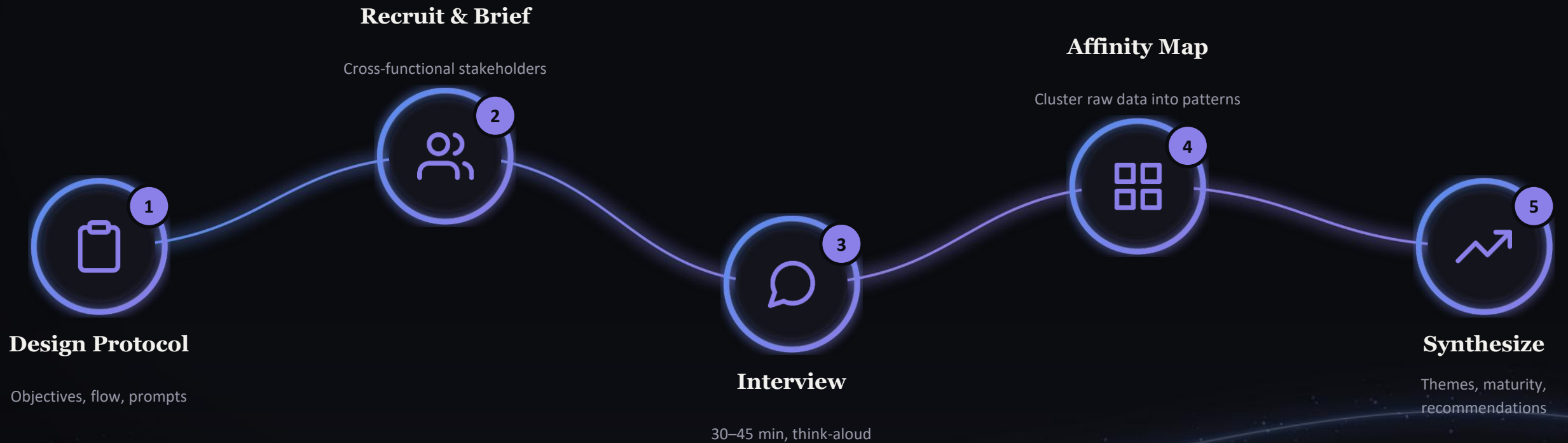
3

Assess organisational readiness for an API Community of Practice and broader ecosystem enablement.

4

Establish qualitative indicators of ecosystem maturity to inform the Community of Practice's design, operating model, and governance approach.

A five-step path from raw conversation to strategic theme



My hand touched every stage of this chain. That continuity is what let subtle, cross-cutting signals like unspoken incentive problems surface in synthesis instead of getting lost in handoffs between researcher, interviewer, and analyst.

Designing a protocol that surfaces behaviour, not opinion

My thinking

- Open with consent, framing, and a think-aloud instruction, the goal was psychological safety, not evaluation.
- Sequence from context → current-state → delivery behaviour → culture → future vision, so trust builds before asking about friction.
- Use scenario-based prompts (“imagine a change is made to a shared API...”) to get concrete behaviour instead of self-reported opinion.
- Write a separate executive track focused on strategic risk, investment, and leadership's role, same themes, different altitude.

Protocol briefly

Opening	Consent, framing, think-aloud (3–5 min)
Their Context	Role, ecosystem relationship, discovery habits (5–7 min)
Current State	What works, friction, reinvention (10–12 min)
Delivery Behaviour	Scenario-based reuse & governance probes (10–12 min)
Culture & Readiness	Knowledge-sharing, incentives, community appetite (8 min)
Future State & Close	2-year vision, biggest lever, referrals (8 min)

Getting honest signals

Who I spoke to

16 interviews across 7 stakeholder groups

-  Solution Architects
-  Subject Matter Experts (SMEs)
-  Business Analysts
-  Developers
-  UX Designers
-  Heads of APIs
-  Executives & business stakeholders

Each session ran 30–45 minutes, was recorded with consent for analysis only

How I ran the room

Framed it as diagnosis, not audit

Told every stakeholder explicitly that this wasn't performance evaluation. That opened candour about failures and workarounds.

Named the observers

Silent note-takers were disclosed upfront, so nobody was surprised mid-conversation, protecting trust in the process.

Followed energy, not just the script

Used open follow-up prompts (“walk me through a recent example...”) to chase specificity wherever a stakeholder got animated.

Watched for what wasn't said

Hesitation, deflection, and vague answers around ownership and incentives were as telling as direct complaints.

Turning interview transcripts into defensible themes

01

Fragment

Broke every transcript into single observations, one sticky note, one idea, stripped of speaker identity.

02

Cluster

Grouped observations bottom-up by underlying behaviour, not by which question prompted them.

03

Label

Named each cluster as a pattern (e.g. discovery friction, fragmented ownership) and checked it against multiple stakeholder groups.

04

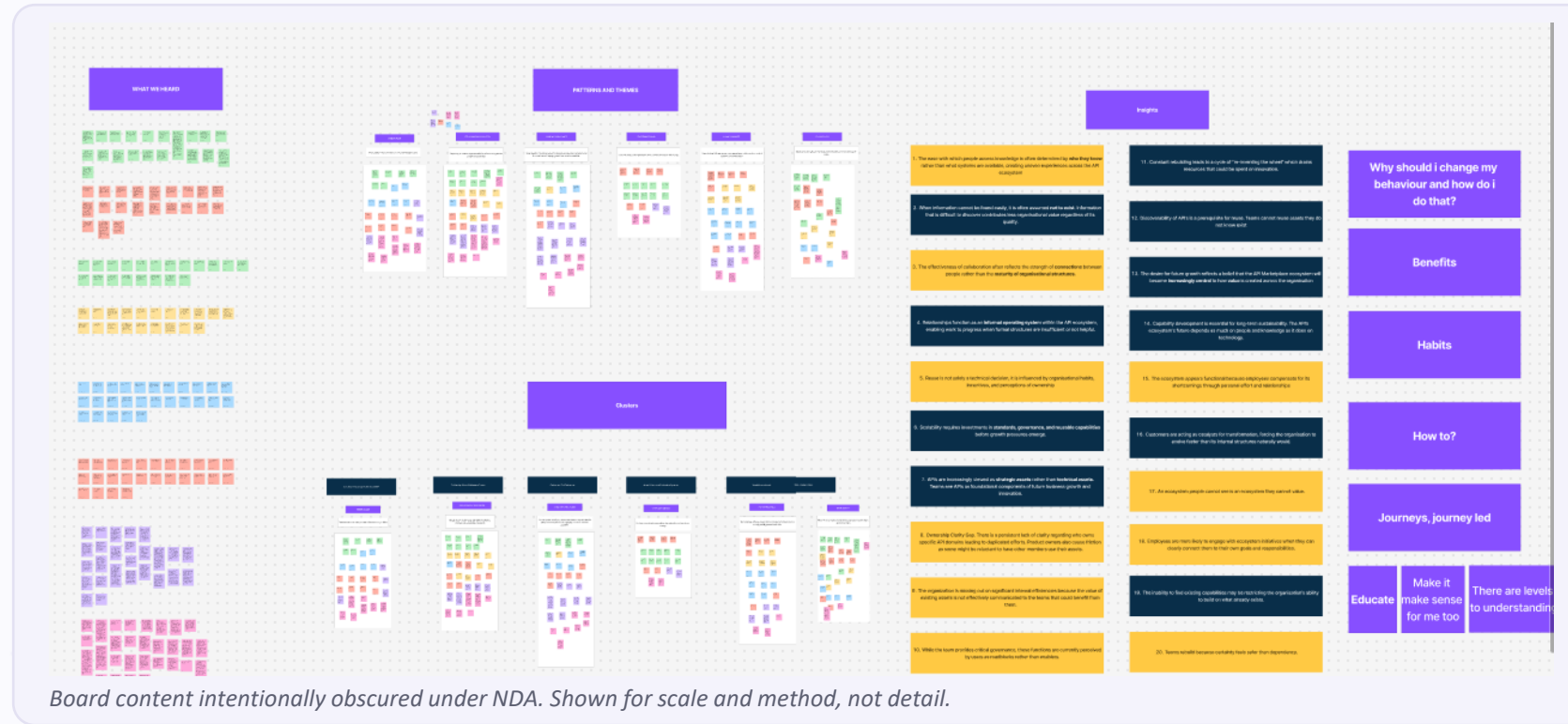
Weight & Prioritize

Scored clusters by frequency, intensity, and business impact to separate systemic themes from one-off anecdotes.



I ran this as a facilitated exercise with the wider project team about what a pattern really meant before it became a “finding.” That gave the final themes more credibility with leadership.

The affinity map, from raw notes to insights



What we heard

Single observations from the 16 interviews, on colour-coded notes.

Patterns & clusters

Notes grouped bottom-up by behaviour, then labelled as themes.

20 insights

Themes sharpened into numbered statements. Three are generalised on slide 11.

The board closes with behaviour-change questions, like “Why should I change my behaviour and how do I do that?”, which became the springboard for the ideation session.

Six themes emerged, the deepest ran behavioural

Discovery is people-dependent

Teams found APIs through tribal knowledge and personal networks, not systems, confidence in “what exists” was low across every group.

Fragmented ownership

Unclear accountability for shared capabilities discouraged reuse and made governance feel like friction rather than support.

Duplication is normalised

Reinventing capability was seen as lower-risk than finding and trusting someone else’s, a rational response to poor visibility.

Governance felt like a gate

Process was associated with delay, not enablement, which pushed teams toward workarounds.

Deep-rooted habits

Ways of working had calcified over years; “how we’ve always done it” outweighed the case for a new shared model.

Incentives don't reward reuse

Recognition and delivery pressure both favoured shipping something new over reusing or contributing to shared capability.

Highlighted themes (5–6) were the deepest and most consequential, cultural habits and incentive structures that no amount of tooling could fix on its own.

What the themes mean for the Community of Practice

01

People over platforms

INSIGHT When deciding what to reuse, teams trusted people they knew over what the platform listed.

IMPLICATION Make people part of discovery: findable owners and named contacts beside every API.

02

Rebuilding feels safer

INSIGHT Building fresh was the lower-risk choice whenever finding and vetting someone else's work was harder.

IMPLICATION Lower the cost of trusting a shared API so that reuse becomes the easy default.

03

Reuse has no payoff

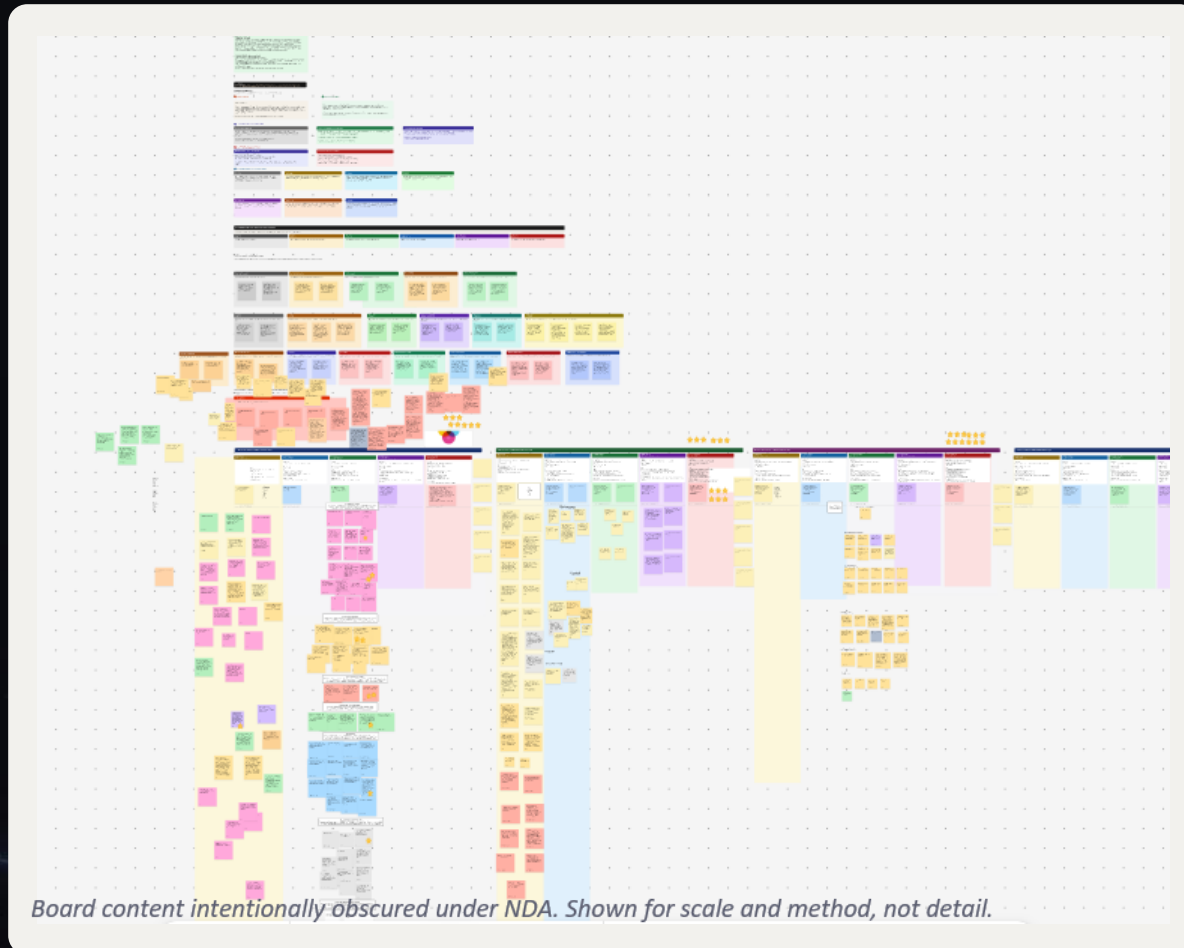
INSIGHT Recognition and delivery pressure both reward shipping something new, so reuse costs effort without credit.

IMPLICATION Recognise reuse and contribution as valued work, not as extra process.



Worded in general terms to protect the client. These three are distilled from the six themes on the previous slide; the full set of 20 insights stays on the board.

From insight to ideas, built with the bank



How I facilitated it

1

Shared back the insights

Walked the team and the bank's stakeholders through the affinity map so everyone worked from the same evidence.

2

Reframed them as questions

Turned insights into behaviour-change questions: why should I change, and how do I do it?

3

Diverged together

Mixed groups generated ideas on sticky notes across journeys, habits and benefits.

4

Converged on priorities

Grouped the ideas and marked the ones the room rallied behind (the stars on the board).

Why the ideation session mattered

01

Shared ownership

The people who will run the Community of Practice helped shape it, so the ideas were theirs, not handed down by the design team.

02

Tested in the room

Hearing the insights played back live let the bank confirm, challenge or sharpen them before anything was designed.

03

Co-created change

The deepest blockers were habits and incentives. People change habits they help redesign, which a report alone can't achieve.



I facilitated the session so the team and the bank's stakeholders could work on one shared board. What came out of it fed straight into the machine-to-organism reframe on the next slide.

From a machine to an organism

Because the deepest blockers were habits and incentives, tooling alone (the Marketplace platform) wouldn't fix them. We recommended reframing the Community of Practice's operating model itself.



Today: the Machine model

- Fixed parts, fixed processes: designed once, expected to run unchanged
- Central control; teams execute a defined sequence rather than adapt it
- Efficient when conditions are stable; brittle when context shifts
- Reuse and collaboration are steps in a process, not behaviours that are rewarded



Proposed: the Organism model

- Self-organizing parts that sense conditions and adapt continuously
- Distributed ownership: everyone grows and tends the ecosystem
- Resilient by design: keeps working even as teams, priorities, and technology shift
- Reuse and contribution are incentivized as healthy behaviours, not extra process

Where this stands today



The themes, maturity read, and machine-to-organism reframe were delivered to leadership as the evidence base for the Community of Practice's design.

What this contributed

- A defensible, traceable evidence base, every theme maps back to multiple stakeholder voices, not anecdote.
- A reframed problem statement: this is a culture and incentive challenge as much as a platform one.
- A shared vocabulary ("machine vs. organism") that gave leadership a fast way to discuss trade-offs.

Reflection

The deepest blockers were rarely technical, and I only caught that because I stayed close to the work from protocol through synthesis, alongside the wider team. Going forward, I want to protect that continuity earlier in a project and resist reaching for a tooling fix before checking whether the real barrier is habits or behavioural."